

HackPGH Project Proposal and Audience Analysis

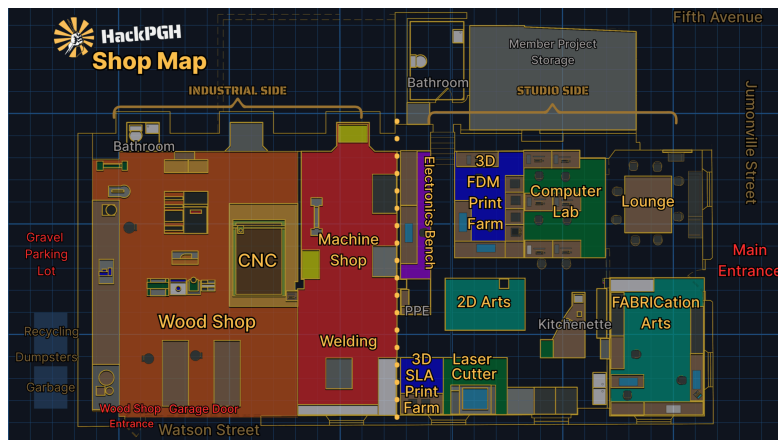
Context

HackPGH is Pittsburgh's first and oldest makerspace, completely independent and volunteer-run since 2009, providing a safe location, equipment, and community where makers can collaborate, learn, and socialize. Located in Pittsburgh's Uptown neighborhood, HackPGH is a 100% volunteer-run community makerspace and registered 501(c)(3) charitable organization.

The organization operates on a member-supported model. Membership costs \$75/month for 24/7 RFID access and communal training on almost all tools and machines, with discounted rates available for students, seniors, active armed services members, veterans, and persons with disabilities. Members are also required to regularly volunteer in some capacity (training others, contributing to group projects, or maintaining the shop) reinforcing the organization's fundamentally community-driven structure.

With eleven shop areas and a wide variety of tools, HackPGH offers resources spanning woodworking, welding, 3D printing, laser cutting, electronics, and more. Beyond individual making, HackPGH regularly hosts food and clothing drives, pop-up vaccine clinics, and other mutual aid initiatives, all open to the general public.

Central to HackPGH's current organizational vision is their "Third Place Makerspace" initiative. The initiative aims to remove fiscal roadblocks, create classes that teach valuable life skills, and improve the shop and its equipment. This specifically benefits persons with disabilities, seniors, and the fiscally challenged, those who are usually excluded from makerspace activities due to cost or accessibility issues. However, inflation and other factors have made it more difficult for HackPGH to grant financial assistance, with less funding available to help those in need.



Socials & Links

<https://www.facebook.com/HackPgh/>

<https://www.instagram.com/hackpgh/>

<https://www.meetup.com/hackpgh/>

<https://www.youtube.com/@hackpittsburgh1349/featured>

<https://github.com/hackpgh>

Interesting video talking about the mission change:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L SqzlgLjhw>

Audience

Creative personnel interested in critical making. Not necessarily college graduates (Open Lab and other services which I assume should be free to students). Adults living within the Pittsburgh region. People with a decent amount of income (since they have to pay for membership). People who value connection and community.

Persona 1

Maya, 31, graphic designer, Lawrenceville. Has a stable income and a creative job but craves hands-on making outside of screen-based work. Wants community with like-minded people. Doesn't know HackPGH exists or assumes it's only for engineers. Spends time on Instagram and local Pittsburgh Reddit. Would act if she saw real people like her using the space and making tangible things.

Persona 2

Will, 19, recent high school grad, Homewood. Mechanically curious, loves taking things apart, no clear career path yet. Can't afford the \$75/month membership. Doesn't see himself represented in HackPGH's current marketing. Mostly on TikTok and YouTube. Would engage if he knew scholarships or discounted memberships existed and saw people from his background at the space.

Persona 3

James, 48, program officer at a Pittsburgh community foundation. Evaluates nonprofits for grants. Needs to see clear evidence of community impact, equity focus, and organizational stability. Reads LinkedIn and nonprofit sector publications. Would fund HackPGH if their materials clearly communicated the Third Place mission and showed measurable outreach to underserved populations.

Communication

HackPGH's primary active social media presence is Facebook, where they post several times per month. However, their content strategy leans heavily towards event calendar announcements rather than experiential storytelling (showing what is happening but not what it feels like to be there). Their other social media platforms appear inconsistently maintained. Despite operating in Pittsburgh for over 15 years, their social media engagement remains relatively low, suggesting the organization has not yet built a broad public audience beyond its existing member base.

A notable gap is the absence of user-generated content. There are few visible reviews, member stories, or volunteer perspectives across platforms that would help prospective audiences see themselves in the space. Event registration is handled through their website, creating an extra step that may reduce spontaneous participation.

HackPGH is telling a more logistical story when they need to be telling a human one. Their current communication shows the schedule but not the soul, which are the processes, the outcomes, the connections, and the sense of belonging that actually define the HackPGH experience.

Narrative Angle

This campaign is built around "The Third Place," a concept HackPGH itself has adopted to describe its vision of a free, open community space between home and work. While the term originates in sociology, it resonates urgently today as Americans experience rising rates of loneliness and the slow disappearance of genuinely inclusive public gathering spaces. HackPGH represents a rare answer to that problem in Pittsburgh, but most people don't know it exists, and many who do assume it isn't for them.

The campaign will argue that HackPGH is not just a workshop. It is one of Pittsburgh's last truly open communities that is built by volunteers, sustained by curiosity, and available to anyone willing to show up. Every component of this campaign will tell that story from a different angle, centering the human experiences of making, belonging, and mutual aid that define what HackPGH actually is.

Rhetorical Situation

HackPGH has operated in Pittsburgh for over 15 years with a compelling mission and a dedicated volunteer community, yet its public narrative remains underdeveloped. Low social media engagement and event-focused content have left most Pittsburghers either unaware of the organization or uncertain whether it is meant for them. This campaign exists to close that gap.

The campaign targets three distinct audiences: creative professionals seeking community, underserved residents who would benefit from HackPGH's scholarship and accessibility programs, and community funders who need to see clear evidence of social impact.

HackPGH's current digital presence is concentrated on its website and Facebook, with inconsistent activity on other platforms. The organization has no paid staff, limiting its capacity for content creation. The \$75/month membership fee creates a real tension with the inclusivity message the campaign seeks to amplify.

The purpose of the campaign is to shift public perception of HackPGH from a niche technical workshop to a vital, welcoming community space, and to move each target audience toward a specific action: visiting, joining, or funding.

Citations

<https://www.hackpgh.org/>

<https://www.facebook.com/HackPgh/>

https://www.reddit.com/r/pittsburgh/comments/6g46sz/we_are_the_leaders_of_hackpgh_ask_us_anything/